During the 1950s, the popular notion was that they could solve the world's problems of famine and sickness by killing pests that destroyed crops and transmitted disease. Advertising campaigns of chemical giants such as Union Carbide, DuPont, Mobil, and Shell spread this message to a huge audience. *Silent Spring* aimed to challenge the received wisdom, arguing that the so-called scientific progress enjoyed in post-war America would come at a huge price for the environment.

The most notorious of the pesticides, and the one most associated with *Silent Spring*, was DDT. It was first synthesized in the late 19th century, but in 1939, Swiss chemist Paul Hermann Müller realized that it could be used to kill a wide range of insects, due to its pervasive action as a nerve poison. It was used during World War II to control insects that destroyed vital food crops as well as those which transmitted malaria, typhus, and dengue fever to combat troops.

DDT proved cheap to produce, highly effective, and at first appeared to pose no threat to human beings. After the war, with the chemical in plentiful supply, its use in agriculture was an obvious next step. With its wide range of apparently safe applications, it must have seemed like a panacea to farmers, who happily sprayed it on their crops, often without the use of masks or protective clothing, because they did not fully appreciate the powerful toxicity of this dangerous chemical compound.

After DDT came a whole host of synthetic agrochemicals, including aldrin, dieldrin, endrin, parathion, malathion, captan, and 2,4-D. Used in conjunction with fertilizers made out of surplus nitrogen that was no longer needed to make explosives, these chemicals enabled the intensification of farming. The chemical age had dawned and by 1952, there were almost 10,000 separate new pesticide products registered with the US Department of Agriculture (USDA).